

July
2026

ASMIInk

Newsletter of the Archeological Society of Maryland, Inc.



Diagnostic Artifacts Webpage Gets a New Look!

Patricia Samford,
Maryland Archaeological Conservation Lab

The Maryland Archaeological Conservation
Lab and the Maryland Historical Trust are
excited to announce the launch of the



Diagnostic Artifacts website. This redesigned
and expanded version of the popular
Diagnostic Artifacts in Maryland website is
now searchable and mobile-device friendly.
Other new features include links to site
summaries, as well as the following new
sections: thimbles, jaw harps, equestrian
artifacts (bridle bits, saddles, horseshoes, and
horse care), and eating utensils (spoons,
forks, knives). The website's name change

from Diagnostic Artifacts in Maryland to
Diagnostic Artifacts reflects an expanded
initiative to include artifacts from partner
institutions in

PALEO-INDIAN



other states, including Delaware, North
Carolina, Virginia, and New Jersey. It is the
same website you know and love but made
more user-friendly and with loads of new
artifact images! The new website launched
on June 30th, at the same web address used
for the original website.

DIAGNOSTIC ARTIFACTS

ARTIFACT GALLERY



Notes from the Board:

This month I wanted to give a recap of some highlights from the June 13th ASM Board Meeting.

- We are seeking an ASMIInk Newsletter editor to join John Fiveash and Valerie Hall on the Newsletter committee
- The board agreed to develop a proposal to host the ESAF Annual Meeting in 2028 in Western Maryland
- The spring Journal needs one more article before it can be published
- And the Journal's September issue will need some articles
- From Teague's Point
 - analysis of the Bale Seal was very interesting - keep your eye out for images
 - the deep feature was likely a cellar filled with debris
- We use FlippingBooks to host our Journal - we are nearing the limits - considering whether to move to a higher level of service or potentially combine some Issues
- Grant for 2024 Cresaps Fort Field Session - Items are completed and we are about ready to request payout
- Grant for 2025 Teagues Point Field Session - once all expenses are paid we can request funds payout, hopefully late in 2026
- We did not request a grant for the 2026 Field Session, we are using operating funds for this field session

- The CAT program has 70 participants (including 1 new candidate)
- The Field Session committee will meet to discuss some after action items in July
- Board approved expenses to repair/replace equipment including building new 1/8 " screens
 - Will schedule an equipment day this fall - more to come
- We welcomed Ned Edelen, the new President of the Charles County Archaeological Society of Maryland, Inc
- Next Board Meeting is September 12, 2026

Valerie Hall
President, ASM

Upcoming Events

Third Annual Summit of Maryland Indigenous People and Archeologists
September 11, 2026 - 9am - 4pm Hanover, MD (sign up will open in July)

Workshop in Maryland Archeology
September 26, 2026 - Maryland Historical Trust in Crownsville, MD

ASM Annual Meeting
October 10, 2026 - Josiah Henson Museum and Park, Bethesda, MD

[Paleoamerican Odyssey](#)
October 14-17, 2026, Santa Fe, New Mexico

American Indian Heritage Day
November 7, 2026 at Jefferson Patterson Park and Museum

[93rd Annual ESAF Meeting](#)
November 11-15, 2026, Norwalk, CT

ASM Election

John Fiveash, Election Committee

This year is an election year, both for the country and for ASM. Ballots will be sent to all ASM Members and results will be announced at the Annual Fall Meeting in October.

2026 Candidates:

President:

Julia Berg - Julia is a long time member of ASM who was instrumental in forming the Eastern Shore Chapter. She was awarded ASM's Teacher of the Year award for 2025. Julia has also earned certification under ASM's CAT Program.

She is a teacher who has worked to implement archeology into her social sciences curriculum. With Kat Sterner and Sarah Mason, she developed programming to train teachers to bring archeology in their classrooms through hands-on experiences.

Julia currently serves ASM as an At-Large Trustee and manages social media for ASM through our Facebook and Instagram presence on the internet. She has been a presence at the ASM Field Session and other Society activities for several years.

Katharine Fernstrom - Katharine has worked in the field of archaeology for 50 years in the Southwest, in Illinois, and in Maryland.

She has been a member of ASM for 25 years, starting in UPAG, then joining Central Chapter where she works collaboratively with Marshy Point Nature Center and the Natural History Society of Maryland and their archaeology interests.

Most recently she has been serving as Vice President of ASM, learning about the wonderful research initiatives across Maryland and beyond.

Her archaeology research interests include petroglyphs as precolonial murals across North America, and precontact human figures across North America.

Vice President:

Jim Gibb - Jim has been an active member of ASM for over 30 years, providing professional advice in planning and carrying out Society activities and projects. He was the 2006 winner of ASM's William B. Marye Award, given for outstanding contributions to Maryland Archeology.

Over the years, Jim has served as Vice President, Treasurer, At-Large Trustees and as the editor of our journal, Maryland Archeology.

Secretary:

Patricia Melville - Patricia is the current Secretary for ASM, documenting Board of Trustee meetings and providing continuity across its quarterly meetings. Her experience as an archivist has served well in generating meeting notes as well as in providing advice in ASM's efforts to launch a digital archive of documentation that serves as a historical record for the Society.

Treasurer:

Tracy Hayman - Tracy has been active in ASM for several years. In addition to participation at the annual Field Session, she has volunteered for many field activities, such as last year's PaleoDigger session at the Barton Site. She regularly volunteers to do lab work at Crownsville during the weekly

open session run by State Terrestrial Archeologist, Zac Singer.

Membership Secretary:

Ethan Bean - Ethan has served as ASM's Membership Secretary since 2019, overseeing many changes in membership processes as the Society has worked to enter a digital world while maintaining more traditional practices at the same time.

At-Large Trustees:

Lynne Bullhack - Lynne has been a member of ASM for over 25 years and is a major influence in the wider archeological community. An acknowledged expert in ceramics, Lynne has provided many lectures in ceramic fabrication and analysis of indigenous materials. She has served ASM as an At-Large Trustee and is also the Native American Liaison for the Society.

Don Housley - Don Housley is a current Trustee and serves as ASM's Grants Manager. He is a past president of ASM, Inc. and current President of the Mid-Potomac Chapter of ASM. His passion for history and archeology were noted in 2022 when he received the William B. Mayre Award.

Danielle Knight - Danielle Knight is a recent Certified Archaeological Technician (CAT) graduate. She's been a member of the mid-Potomac Chapter ASM since 2023. Danielle is a regular volunteer at the MHT lab in Crownsville and has participated in archaeological excavations and surveys in Maryland, Pennsylvania, Italy, and Belize. She is also a member of the Pre-Columbian Society of Washington, DC.

Brook Leathery - Brook's interest in archaeology started after discovering Native American artifacts close to the house where he grew up in Frederick County. This interest grew after researching local archaeology and eventually led to taking college courses including both Intro to Archaeology and Anthropology.

His professor at FCC, Dr. Lippiello, encouraged students to connect with both ASM and MHT. At FCC, he helped curate artifacts from the Biggs Ford site and presented lectures on my own independent research to archaeology students.

In the summer of 2023, he participated in the Seneca Bluff's STP survey, meeting many ASM members and MHT archaeologists. In 2024 he completed an archeological field school led by Dr. Sterner with Towson University.

Sarah Mason - Sarah has been an active member in ASM for many years and was a leading participant in the resurrection of the Eastern Shore chapter several years ago.

A teacher, she has worked to develop the Trowels to Teaching program with Julia Berg and Kat Sterner. Sarah was awarded an ASM Teacher of the Year Award at the annual Meeting in 2025. She has been a regular participant in the annual Field Session as well as our annual meeting and Symposium.

Emma Moller - Emma is an up-and-coming member of ASM, participating in regular meetings and in field activities such as the PaleoDigger and several Annual Field Sessions.

Curator's Choice

What the Shell Is Up With All These Buttons?

Scott Strickland - MAC Lab Deputy Director

Sometimes it is not just the object itself that is intriguing, but rather the context and history behind it. Buttons are not an uncommon occurrence on archaeological sites. What is unusual is to find many buttons from only limited testing at a site.

A total of 8 buttons were found in shovel



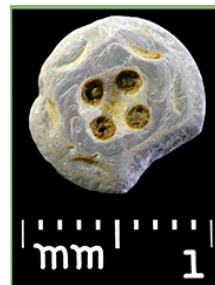
tests in November 2023 at the Straiten site (18CV307), a site that consisted of three dwellings that were part of the larger community known as Wallville, here at Jefferson Patterson park and Museum (JPPM). Site testing sampled less than 2% of the entire site. Recovering this many buttons during just a small survey is very unusual!

Located near the Patterson House at JPPM, the Straiten site gets its name from the Straiten family, who were the last occupants of one of the three dwellings that stood at the site beginning in the early 19th century. The Straiten home was the last of those structures that remained standing into the 1930s, just a stone's throw away from the old Patterson House – where the Patterson House is today.

The site's first occupants were, initially, enslaved families. After emancipation, the dwellings were later lived in by some of the same families and their descendants. In the 1880 census, the household of John W. Peterson included a servant named Georgia Anne Egins. By the 1930 census, Georgia Anne was one of the last residents of the Straiten site, alongside her daughter Georgia and her daughter's husband, James Straiten. As a servant of the Petersons, Georgia Anne may have worked as a laundress.

Of the buttons recovered, one stood out from the rest – a shell button with a hexagonal decoration. Shell

buttons, also called pearl buttons, are made from the pearl-like iridescent lining of marine or freshwater mollusk shells. Shell buttons from the late



18th century and into the first half of the 19th century were typically disc-shaped with a wire pin shank on the back. They were often expensive because they were handmade from fine colorful and iridescent shells originating from warmer climates (Hughes and Lester, 1991).

During the Industrial Revolution in the second half 19th century, buttons were being mass-produced in the United States using less iridescent clam shells available along



the northeastern seaboard and later from freshwater sources along the Mississippi River. Tubular saws were used to cut out several round blanks from the shell.

Holes for fastening to clothing were drilled simultaneously on a drill press. Geometric designs like the one found on the button from the Straiten site were made with a machine engraver in a process called “eccentric lathe work” (Albert and Kent, 1949).

By the 1890s, freshwater mussels found along the Mississippi River became the dominant source for shell buttons, which led to a thriving industry in the Midwest. By 1900, Muscatine, Iowa was dubbed “the Pearl Button Capital of the World,” manufacturing millions of buttons per year. The overharvesting of these shells from the Mississippi created a problem, with sources being depleted around Muscatine and elsewhere – essentially killing the once thriving regional industry. Plastic buttons, which were easier to manufacture, would ultimately replace shell as a prominent button material (Sirmans, 2023).

A shell button manufacturing industry grew on the Delmarva Peninsula in Maryland and Delaware beginning in the 1930s, using shells imported from the Mississippi Valley and around the world.. Archaeologists from the Smithsonian Environmental Research Center documented three factories that

remained in operation for several decades: the Schwanda factory in Denton (1936-1996), Martinek’s button shop on Elliot Island (1949-1992) and Parizek’s button shop (1940-1972) near Milford, Delaware (Biuk, 2018).

The Straiten site was abandoned in the early 1930s, so it was unlikely that the button originated from these more local shops and factories. It was most likely produced sometime during the second half of the 19th century. Evidence points to Georgia Anne being the last person to touch it. Putting a name to a specific object is pretty rare in archaeology!

References Cited:

Albert, Lillian Smith and Kathryn Kent

1949 *The Complete Button Book*. Doubleday & Company, Inc. Garden City, New York

Buik, Siara L.

2018 *Shell Button-Making on the Delmarva Peninsula, ca. 1930s-1990s*. In *Northeast Historical Archaeology*, Vol 47, Article 3.

Hatton, Jaquie M.

2001 *Shell Buttons*, Keep Homestead Museum, Monsoon Mass.

Hughes, Elizabeth and Marion, Lester

1991 *The Big Book of Buttons*, New Leaf Publishers, Sedwick

Maine.Sirmans, Harikleia

2023 *The Pearl-Button Fever: Fishing Fortunes from the Mississippi River Bend*., *Piecework Magazine*, March 27, 2024

[CURATOR’S CHOICE](#) is provided by the Maryland Archaeological Conservation Lab.

Summer 2026 ASM, Inc. New Project Applications

It's time for the next ASM New Project process, applications are now being accepted.

- Applicants should submit the ASM Project Request Form (attached) along with any supporting documentation to: Valerie.Hall@marylandarcheology.org
- As they are received, the ASM, Inc. New Project Review Group (appointed by the ASM President) will review and:
 - Provide a recommendation or
 - Ask for additional information
- If a project is recommended by the New Project Review Group, the Proposal will be brought to the Executive Board for Vote
- Decisions will be provided to the requestor and published in the Ink
- For 2026, we have a suggested cap of \$5,000 per request (but all requests will certainly be considered).
- Grantees will be expected to provide a brief article for the Ink and submit a Journal article for consideration.

We look forward to reading and reviewing your projects!

If you have questions or need additional information, contact Valerie.Hall@marylandarcheology.org.



Waterscreening . . . ?

Chapter News

Central Chapter

Central Chapter meetings are by Zoom only. Katharine Fernstrom sends the link to the email group. Stay tuned for more details. For more information and to be added to the Zoom list contact Katharine Fernstrom at katharine.fernstrom@marylandarcheology.org

Charles County

Meets in person September through April at the Community Room of the LaPlata Police Department in LaPlata, MD on the third Thursday of the month. Email ccasm2010@gmail.com for more information.

Eastern Shore

Dates and events are on chapter's website ([ASM Eastern Shore](#)), Facebook page ([Eastern Shore Maryland Archaeology](#)) and Instagram (@esmdarch). For more information, email esarcheology@gmail.com or jamrkin2@washcoll.edu

Calendar is here: bit.ly/ASM-ES and events are open to members and nonmembers. To be added to our social media updates, email esarcheology@gmail.com.

All events are open to anyone who wants to attend!

Open lab at Washington College: Contact Julie Markin at jmarkin2@washcoll.edu.

Mid-Potomac

The chapter meets the third Thursday of the month from September through June. In-person meetings begin at 7p.m. for the business meeting followed by a presentation at around 7:30. The chapter meets at the ADU Showroom, 8501 Grovemont Circle, Gaithersburg, MD 20877. Please contact Don Housley for directions, if necessary.

Pizza will be available before the in-person meeting starting at 6:30pm for \$6 per person. If virtual meetings are necessary, they will be via Zoom with the business meeting also starting at 7 p.m. and the presentation around 7:30. Contact Don Housley to RSVP for pizza by 12 noon on the day of the meeting and for virtual Zoom meeting codes.

ASMIInk July 2026

For up-to-date information concerning meetings, please contact [Don Housley](#), 301-424-8526, check the [Mid-Potomac Chapter Website](#) or send an email to: asmmidpotomac@gmail.com.

Monocacy

For information contact: monocacyarcheology@gmail.com (mailbox monitored intermittently) or call Jeremy Lazelle at 301-471-8433.

Northern Chesapeake

A business meeting at 7pm and is followed by the presentation at 7:30. Locations vary. Contact Dan Coates at 410-808-2398 or dancoates@comcast.net

Western Maryland

Programs are held the fourth Friday of the month, at 7:30 pm at the **History Discovery Center at Blue Spring at 400 N. Mechanic Street, Cumberland, MD**. Unless noted. Chapter email: wmdasm@yahoo.com

Meeting announcements are sent also to CTN; WFWM, and the Oakland Republican.

Contact Us

The **Archeological Society of Maryland Inc.** is a statewide nonprofit organization devoted to the study and conservation of Maryland archeology.



ASM members receive the monthly newsletter, ASM Ink, publication notice of the biannual journal, MARYLAND ARCHEOLOGY, reduced admission to ASM events and a 10-percent discount on items sold by the Society.

Contact Membership Secretary Ethan Bean, ethan.bean@marylandarcheology.org, for membership rates.

ASM Officers

President

Valerie Hall

valerie.hall@marylandarcheology.org

301-814-8028

Vice-President

Katharine Fernstrom

katharine.fernstrom@marylandarcheology.org

Secretary

Patricia Melville

pvmelville@verizon.net

Membership Secretary

Ethan Bean

ethan.bean@marylandarcheology.org

Treasurer

Cathy Camut

cathy.camut@marylandarcheology.org

At-Large Trustees

- Lynne Bulhack
- Brent Chippendale
- Danielle Knight
- Don Housley
- Jim Gibb
- Julia Berg

ASMInk Editors:

Valerie Hall -

valerie.hall@marylandarcheology.org

John Fiveash -

jsfiveash@marylandarcheology.org